

Country Profile: South Vietnam (Republic of Vietnam)

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 3
- Plurality religion: Mahayana Buddhism
- Official language: None
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Vietnamese

Historical Background

South Vietnam emerged as a separate state following the French defeat at the Battle of Điện Biên Phủ in 1954 and the subsequent decisions made at the Geneva Conference, which temporarily divided Vietnam into a communist North and a capitalist South. This division reflected broader Cold War dynamics that shaped political developments across Southeast Asia. North Vietnam's victory in the Second Indochina War led to the reunification of the country in 1975, which the NBP dataset records as the South's accession to the North. Domestically, South Vietnam under the Diem regime pursued a policy of strong Vietnamese nationalism, which included efforts to assimilate the Chinese minority population.¹

Groups

- **Vietnamese** were, with 78% population share, the core group of South Vietnam.² They spoke Vietnamese, the national language.³ Mahayana Buddhism was the main religious denominator, making it also the plurality religion of the state. A small minority also practiced Roman Catholicism.⁴

¹ Share, 1994.

² Bormann, 2021.

³ Ethnologue, 2024.

⁴ Joshua Project, 2024.

- **Chinese** in South Vietnam were descendants of migrants from Guangdong who arrived during the 18th century.⁵ They formed only a small segment of the population, around 1%, and spoke variants of the Chinese macro-language, particularly Yue and Hakka, but also Vietnamese and Mandarin Chinese as standardized educational languages.⁶ The absolute majority of Chinese practiced Mahayana Buddhism, with a small share of Roman Catholics.⁷ Chinese are listed as a racialized group: in Vietnam, a distinct census category, *Nguoi Viet goc Hoa*, was used to classify citizens of Chinese origin separately from ethnic Vietnamese until 1964.⁸
- **Montagnards** constituted a nested Indigenous and historically racialized group, accounting for 5% of the South Vietnamese population,⁹ including highland communities such as the **Gia Rai**, **Ba Na**, and **Cham**.¹⁰ They mainly resided in the mountainous provinces of South Vietnam.¹¹ Each group historically maintained its own distinct language, making the population linguistically diverse, with languages such as Jarai (spoken by the Gia Rai), Bahnar (spoken by the Ba Na), and Eastern Cham (spoken by the Cham). However, many have since shifted to using Vietnamese.¹² The religious composition of each subgroup varied considerably. Among the Gia Rai, a majority followed traditional animist beliefs, while a smaller portion adhered to Protestantism. The Ba Na were predominantly animist, with only a minority identifying as Protestant. Within the Cham community, Hinduism represented the largest religious affiliation, followed by notable Muslim and animist minorities.¹³ The Cham minority established the United Liberation Front of Highland Champa (FLC) in 1954, advocating the self-determination of Chams.¹⁴

⁵ Minority Rights, 2018.

⁶ Ethnologue, 2024.

⁷ Joshua Project, 2024.

⁸ Khanh, 1993, 28–29.

⁹ Hickey, 1967.

¹⁰ Minority Rights, 2018.

¹¹ Birnir et al., 2015.

¹² Ethnologue, 2024.

¹³ Joshua Project, 2024.

¹⁴ Sambanis et al., 2018.

State Profile

Official Language

Although the constitution contained no explicit language clause, Vietnamese nonetheless served as the sole working language of the state, appearing in all statutes and official publications. Bills sent to the National Assembly, presidential decrees, and court judgments were consistently drafted in the Romanized Vietnamese script, Quốc Ngữ.

Official Religion

The 1967 Constitution officially stated in Article 9(2) that “No religion is recognized as the State religion. The State is impartial in the development of various religions.”¹⁵

Education Policies

The South Vietnamese education system emerged from the French system following the state’s independence. Particularly during the 1960s, the education system was sustained with U.S. educational aid, which led to the “Americanization” of the system—especially in higher education.¹⁶ The system comprised public, semi-private and **private** schools.¹⁷

Language Education Policies

With the state’s declaration of independence, **Vietnamese** had replaced French as the main language of instruction in public schools throughout the country. South Vietnam continued the principle of Vietnamese language education.

In 1966, a joint commission involving the South Vietnamese Ministry of Education, the Commissariat for Ethnic Minorities, and the U.S. Agency for International Development invited the Summer Institute of Linguistics to develop textbooks and train teachers for a Highlander Education Project. This initiative was formalized in Presidential Decree No. 0033/67 (August 29, 1967), which mandated that regional languages be taught alongside Vietnamese in primary schools. In practice, minority languages such as **Jarai**, **Bahnar**, and **Cham** were used both in mandatory language classes and as mediums of instruction

¹⁵ Constitution of the Republic of Vietnam, 1967.

¹⁶ Van Quyet and Huong, 2020.

¹⁷ Dror, 2018.

in primary schools, particularly for subjects like science, health, ethics, and minority group culture.¹⁸

Chinese, however, was not taught in public schools. Reflecting attempts to assimilate the Chinese community, private schools were prohibited to teach in Chinese beginning in 1955,¹⁹ and during the 1960s, the South Vietnamese government mandated the exclusive use of Vietnamese as the language of instruction in all schools. By 1962, Chinese schools were required to adopt Vietnamese as the medium of instruction, with Chinese available only as an optional subject in secondary schools, limited to six hours per week.²⁰

Religious Education Policies

No denominational religious classes were part of the South Vietnamese curriculum, including in private schools.²¹

Bans and Restrictions

In 1956, the adoption of Vietnamese names was made compulsory for members of the Chinese minority, restricting the use of the language for naming purposes.²²

In its final years, the Diem government took repressive actions against Buddhist organizations and, facing protests, declared martial law in 1963 to raid pagodas.²³ The public display of religious symbols was also restricted. This was briefly continued by Gen. Nguyen Khanh in 1964.²⁴

Demographic Engineering and Violence

State-Based Violence and Forced Relocations

State-sponsored violence and forced relocations targeting the Montagnards can be divided into two key periods. The first began in 1955, when the South Vietnamese government abolished the Montagnard autonomous area and initiated land colonization policies, resettling Northern Vietnamese refugees and coastal ethnic Vietnamese into the Central Highlands—the number of people affected reached 50,000 by 1960 and 200,000

¹⁸ Nguyen, 1978, 345–346.

¹⁹ Share, 1994.

²⁰ Huang, 2006.

²¹ UNESCO, 1958.

²² Share, 1994.

²³ JFK Library, 2024.

²⁴ Human Rights Watch, 1995.

by 1963. The second wave occurred under the Strategic Hamlets program, during which Montagnard communities were forcibly relocated from rural areas into fortified villages, contributing to unrest and an armed insurgency led by FULRO; an estimated 1,500 people died as a result of these forced relocations.²⁵

Cultural Elimination

The large-scale colonialization of Montagnard concentration areas by Vietnamese²⁶ constituted population dilution and, paired with attempts to forcefully “civilize” and “Vietnamize” the inhabitants,²⁷ marked a clear effort towards cultural elimination.

As part of the assertion of Vietnamese nationalism by the South Vietnamese government and the pivot of its attention towards the country’s Chinese communities, Chinese minorities also faced suppression of intangible expressions of their collective identity, aimed as eradicating Chineseness from South Vietnam.²⁸

Constitutions and Laws

South Vietnam was governed by three constitutions during its existence as an independent state, adopted in 1956, 1965, and 1967. The constitutions did not make reference to any particular ethnic group and refrained from establishing an official language or recognizing an official religion. Universal religious liberties were protected by the 1956 Constitution. Such provisions were absent in the 1965 Charta but reintroduced by the 1967 Constitution, mandating that “[t]he State respects and guarantees the freedom of religious belief and the freedom of every citizen to preach and practice religion” (Art. 9(1)).

Citizenship Laws

The South Vietnamese citizenship regime followed the *jus sanguinis* principle, with nationality being passed down by descent. As such, there was no birthright citizenship for children born to foreign parents in the state’s territory.

Beginning in 1956, a South Vietnamese decree required ethnic Chinese to exchange their identity cards for Vietnamese ones; the measure was compulsory, retroactive, and applied nationwide. Those who did not comply were classified as foreigners and subject

²⁵ Salemink, 2003.

²⁶ McLeod, 1999.

²⁷ McLeod, 1999.

²⁸ Share, 1994.

to heavy taxes, while a separate decree soon after mandated all Vietnamese citizens to adopt Vietnamese names or face a substantial fine.²⁹

National Anthem(s)

After its establishment based on the Geneva Accord, South Vietnam adopted *Thanh niên Hành Khúc*, previously used during the independence struggle as the unofficial anthem of the Provisional Central Government of Vietnam (which became the government of South Vietnam), as the national anthem. The revised lyrics that served official purposes include references to blood and to national ancestors, such as the “sons of the Lac-Hong.” Mentions of martyrdom and the national territory, “from North to South,” are also featured in the text. While the lyrics draw an image of nationhood, it remains ambiguous and is not associated with a particular group.³⁰

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²⁹ Share, 1994.

³⁰ Nationalanthems.info, 2024.

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